



Caterpillar diet

Postman butterflies become poisonous very early in their life. Their caterpillars eat leaves of passion vines, which contain toxic cyanide. The poison stays in their bodies without harming them, even as they turn into butterflies. Adults also only feed on passion vines, but on the nectar and pollen of its flowers.

Guiana Highlands

In this area of tabletop mountains rising steeply from rainforests, the butterflies have little or no white in their color pattern—similar to those of the Andean mountains.

Central America

In the rainforests from Guatemala to Panama, postman butterflies have red bands on their forewings and white bands, sometimes tinged with yellow, on their hind wings.

Andes

High up in the mountain valleys and foothills of the northern Andes range, the butterflies' hind wings have less white; some have no white in their pattern at all.

Regional colors

Some species of butterfly have many different varieties according to where they live. The postman butterfly, for example, has more than 20 variations.

Some of these are shown on this map, in the areas where they live.

Postman butterfly

The postman butterfly lives in varied habitats from Central to South America. Across its range, its exact pattern of red, black, and white varies from place to place. A flash of color from any postman butterfly is a sign that it is poisonous, so helps keep predatory birds away.

THERE ARE ABOUT **20,000**
SPECIES OF BUTTERFLY
IN THE **WORLD**



AT NIGHT, POSTMAN BUTTERFLIES
GATHER TO SLEEP IN GROUPS
KNOWN AS **COMMUNAL ROOSTS**

